The Three Swine of Most Small Stature

By Lewy Olfson

NOTE: The acting should be highly stylized, with the actors pantomiming most of the action in pseudo-Oriental fashion. STAGE MANAGER bows low to audience

STAGE MANAGER: O most revered audience, welcome to Imperial Theater of the Orient. I, Oriental Stage Manager, beg your humble attention. Wish to have your permission to introduce play. (Wish to introduce play even ***without*** your permission, since actors have been rehearsing for a whole week!) Play tells very ancient and honorable legend: legend of the Three Swine of Most Small Stature. Called in translation, "The Three Little Pigs." Perhaps you have read legend already, in which case. feel free to nap during performance. However, must warn you that legend in English not so beautiful as legend in Chinese. In Chinese is very symbolic… very aesthetic. Also very hard to understand if you don't speak Chinese! *(Gong sounds offstage.)* Ah, So! Signal means, "get this show on the road!"*(Bows)* The Three Swine of Most Small Stature! *(He claps his.)*

INTRODUCTION

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The three Pigs are dancing and skipping about.

STAGE MANAGER: Behold! A woodland glade in ancient China. Notice: only one tree for scenery. One tree suggests entire woodland. Very symbolic. Very aesthetic. *(Claps hands. PIGS stop frolicking and stand in line.)*Beg to introduce chief characters. *(PIGS step forward and bow as their names are called.)* Number One Pig. *(He bows.)* Number Two Pig. *(He bows.)* Number Three Pig. *(He bows.)* Play has one other character. We will introduce him later. For

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one thing, wish to build suspense. For another thing, he takes a long time to get into his costume. *(The gong sounds.)* Signal! Signal means: "Let play begin!"

NUMBER ONE PIG: Brother pigs, what a happy life we live here in ancient China.

NUMBER TWO PIG: You have spoken wisely, Number One Pig. Ours is a most carefree existence.

NUMBER THREE PIG: Nothing to do but sing and play, all day long.

NUMBER ONE PIG: Yes, fun is good. But when I spoke of pleasure, I meant also the pleasure of work. The pleasure of going to school. The pleasure of meeting challenges and pursuing honest toil.

NUMBER TWO PIG: What a party-pooper you are, Number One Pig! Number Three Pig and I don't believe in all that work stuff.

NUMBER THREE PIG: Naw, we just want to dance and sing and have a good time all day long.

NUMBER ONE PIG: Foolish, foolish pigs! Listen to me, your elder brother. All play and no work make for great unhappiness!

NUMBER TWO PIG: Says who!

NUMBER ONE PIG: Old saying of Confucius.

NUMBER TWO PIG *(Disgusted)*: Ah, you and your high-flown ideas! Just because you went to college, you're always showing off.

NUMBER THREE PIG: You used to be a regular guy, Number One Pig. But ever since you got your Ph.D. — in Pig Latin — have you been a grouch!

NUMBER ONE PIG: You may scoff at me now, my brothers. But one day you will see I am right.

STAGE MANAGER *(Rising, addressing audience)*: Number One Pig wasn't exaggerating. He knew that summer could not last forever. Behold: Winter! *(He hangs a giant snowflake cutout on the tree.)* Cold, cold, cold winter — the worst winter in the history of China. Notice: Only one snowflake for scenery. very symbolic. very aesthetic.

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NUMBER THREE PIG: Also very cheap.

STAGE MANAGER: Now came the time to work, just as Number One Pig had predicted.

NUMBER ONE PIG: My brothers, it is winter. We can no longer live out of doors. I think it is time to build a pagoda.

NUMBER TWO PIG *(Sarcastically)*: It's really terrific to have a college graduate in the family. It's been snowing for a month now, and it's finally dawned on him to build us a house.

NUMBER THREE PIG: I was wondering when you were going to get around to it, Number One Pig.

NUMBER ONE PIG *(Smugly)*: But, my brothers, I am not going to build us a house. I am going to build me a house. You must build houses for yourselves.

NUMBER TWO PIG: Big deal. I guess we can build as good a house as you can if we want to.

NUMBER ONE PIG: We shall see. What will you build your house of, Number Three Pig?

NUMBER THREE PIG: I shall build my house of tatami mats. I know where I can get a real buy on some straw tatami mats, imported from Japan.

NUMBER ONE PIG: If I may say so, esteemed, honorable, and revered brother, it's a stupid idea. I might call it tatami-rot!

NUMBER TWO PIG: Oink!

NUMBER ONE PIG: And what will you build your house of, Number Two Pig?

NUMBER TWO PIG: I shall build my house of chopsticks. I can get second-hand chopsticks free down at the Chinese restaurant.

NUMBER ONE PIG: House of straw! House of sticks! Is terrible architecture.

NUMBER TWO PIG *(Wagging his finger; brightly)*: But is symbolic!

NUMBER THREE PIG: *(Likewise)*: Is aesthetic!

NUMBER ONE PIG: *(Proudly)*: I shall build my house of bricks.

NUMBER TWO PIG: Bricks! But bricks cost a fortune!

NUMBER THREE PIG: Where would you get the money?

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NUMBER ONE PIG: Have been making regular deposits at the Piggy Bank. You forget: I am college graduate. I really know how to bring home the bacon.

NUMBER TWO PIG: Oink!

STAGE MANAGER *(Rising)*: And so, the Three Swine of Most Small Stature set to work to build themselves the best pagodas they could manage. *(PIGS pantomime building houses.)* Number One Pig built his house of bricks, while Number Two Pig built his of chopsticks and Number Three Pig used tatami. And when the pagodas were finished, how pleased the pigs were. . . Story now becomes complicated. Is late one night. Each pig sits in his own pagoda. No scenery for night. No scenery for pagodas. Audience must use imagination. We blew budget on the snowflake. Suddenly, out of the woods comes dark, mysterious figure. *(WON TON WOLFenters and slinks around at back of stage.)* Wicked creature. Evil creature. Hush! Plot thickens! *(WOLF pretends to knock on door of straw house by stamping his foot on the stage as he raps his hand in the air.)*

WOLF: O, most revered Number Three Pig, I beg you to give me admittance to your snug little pagoda.

NUMBER THREE PIG: Who is that knocking on my door?

WOLF: It is I, your humble friend and neighbor Won Ton Wolf. Let me in, let me in!

NUMBER THREE PIG: Not by the hair of my Chinny Chin-Chin.

WOLF *(Perplexed)*: What the heck is a Chinny Chin-Chin?

NUMBER THREE PIG: Oh. Is my girlfriend. Her name is Chin-Chin. "Chinny" is her nickname.

WOLF *(Still perplexed)*: Well, what on earth does her hair have to do with it?

NUMBER THREE PIG: Her hair is her most beautiful feature. It is what caused me to fall in love with her. *(Sings)* "I dream of Chinny with the light brown hair. . . ."

WOLF *(Disgusted)*: What is this, Chinese amateur night? Let me in, I say!

NUMBER THREE PIG: Never!

WOLF: Then I'll huff and I'll puff and I'll blow your house in!

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NUMBER THREE PIG: And then what will you do?

WOLF *(Laughing wickedly)*: I'll turn you into pork chow mein!

STAGE MANAGER *(As WOLF huffs and puffs)*: So Wolf huffed. Wolf puffed. Son of Confucius! Wolf blew house in! *(NUMBER THREE PIG falls over.)* Fortunately, Pig escaped to pagoda of Number Two Pig. *(NUMBER THREE PIG runs over to NUMBER TWO PIG.)*

NUMBER THREE PIG: Listen, brother, I'm in big trouble. May I spend the night with you?

NUMBER TWO PIG: Of course. But what happened? *(WOLF knocks at door of second house.)*

NUMBER THREE PIG: Never mind. I think it's about to happen again.

WOLF: O, most noble and esteemed Number Two Pig, let me in, let me in.

NUMBER TWO PIG *(To NUMBER THREE PIG)*: Who can that be?

NUMBER THREE PIG *(Dryly)*: Well, it ain't Madame Butterfly.

NUMBER TWO PIG *(Dramatically)*: You mean — ?

NUMBER THREE PIG: *(Nodding)*: Yep. Won Ton Wolf.

NUMBER TWO PIG *(To WOLF)*: You've got to be kidding. O most feared and vicious wolf. Never will I lot you in, not by the hair of my brother's Chinny Chin-Chin. *(Pause)* Aren't you going to ask me what a Chinny Chin-Chin is?

WOLF: Forget it. Been there. Done that. Are you going to open up or do I go into my huff-and-puff stuff?

NUMBER TWO PIG: What will you do if I let you in?

WOLF: I'll turn you into Barbecued Spare Ribs with Sesame Soy Sauce.

STAGE MANAGER *(As WOLF huffs)*: Again, Wolf huffed. Wolf puffed. Again, success! *(NUMBER TWO PIG and NUMBER THREE PIG fall over.)* Sky looked as if it was raining chopsticks. Just in nick of time, Number Two Pig and Number Three Pig made it to pagoda of Number One Pig. *(They race over to NUMBER ONE PIG.)*

NUMBER ONE PIG: O my most honorable brothers, to what do I owe the esteemed pleasure of this unexpected visit?

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NUMBER TWO PIG: It's Won Ton Wolf!

NUMBER THREE PIG: He's after us!

NUMBER ONE PIG *(Smugly)*: Why did you not seek refuge in your own pagodas?

NUMBER THREE PIG: All right, don't rub it in. That tatami of mine just shriveled to bits. It never pays to buy cheap foreign merchandise.

NUMBER TWO PIG: And my chopsticks weren't much use, either. You were very clever, Number One Pig, to build your house of bricks.

NUMBER ONE PIG *(Modestly)*: Well, to tell the truth, I didn't get the idea by myself. Read it in a fortune cookie.

NUMBER THREE PIG: Who cares how you got the idea! Will you let us stay with you?

NUMBER ONE PIG: Do you think I'd throw my esteemed brothers into the cold, and keep all this warmth for myself? What do you take me for — a pig?

STAGE MANAGER: So the Three Swine of Most Small Stature waited in their safe brick pagoda for the arrival of their enemy. He was not long in showing up.

WOLF *(Pretending to knock)*: O, most esteemed Number One Pig, let me in, let me in.

THREE PIGS *(In unison, singing)*: "I dream of Chinny with the light brown hair…"

WOLF *(Angrily)*: Oh, you're pulling that on me, are you? O.K. wise guys, prepare yourselves for some huffing and puffing that'll blow you all into won ton soup!

STAGE MANAGER *(As WOLF huffs)*: Wolf huffed. Wolf puffed. But, lo! Brick pagoda did not give way. Number One Pig had built it too strongly. Pigs were safe! Wolf was outfoxed!

WOLF *(To STAGE MANAGER)*: Oh, yeah? Well, there's more than one way to skin a kumquat. I have a sneaky plan that will get me into that pagoda even if it is made of bricks.

STAGE MANAGER: What's your plan?

WOLF *(Triumphantly)*: I'll climb up on the roof and drop down the chimney! Just wait'll I get a ladder. *(WOLF exits. Gong is heard. Stage Manager turns to*

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audience.) Stage Manager: O most revered audience, it would be a pleasure to show you outcome of devious plat of Won Ton Wolf. However, is impossible in our humble theater. Not enough money to show roof. Not enough money to show chimney. Not even enough money for symbolic, aesthetic ladder. Besides, actor playing wolf afraid of heights. However, I can tell you how story ended. Number One Pig said:

NUMBER ONE PIG: O, my brothers, after your adventure in the cold, wintry night, I'll bet you'd like a cup of nice hot Formosa Oolong tea. I will just set a giant cauldron of water — which I just happen to have lying about the house — in the fireplace and let it come to a boil.

NUMBER TWO PIG: You really shouldn't bother, Number One Pig.

NUMBER THREE PIG: Yes, why go to all that trouble?

NUMBER ONE PIG: Well, you never can tell. Someone may be dropping in.

STAGE MANAGER: And so, clever Number One Pig came up with stratagem that cooked wolf's goose. But in any case, Wolf would have met sad fate, and story would have had happy ending. For as it is written in ancient, honorable Chinese proverb, "He who drops down Oriental chimney comes down with case of Hong Kong flue." Get it? Flu? *(Bows low. Blackout and quick curtain.)*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Lewy Olfson
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AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier – HI
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